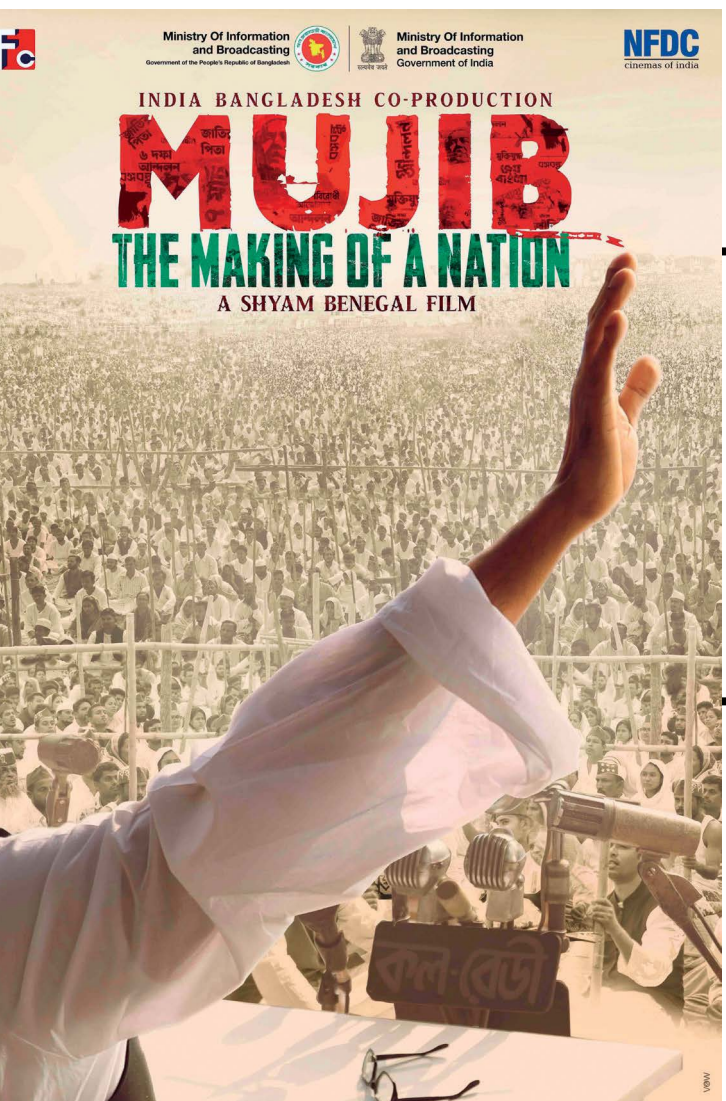
What was Shyam Benegal's first film? And which biopic did he star in? The second question first. Benegal's father was a photographer, and also had a movie camera at home. The birth of a child in the family signalled the start of loving documentation of the infant's moments and landmarks. Baby Shyam was the subject of a documentary of his infancy. But his first film? It wasn't *Ankur*. Or the first of the documentaries he made before that. It wasn't any of the hundreds of advertising films and sponsored documentaries he made when he was in that industry. It was a 100 per cent indie effort. When young Shyam was 12, his father permitted him the use of his movie camera, and the boy used it to record the happenings of the school holidays in the family home, edited it, and called it *Chhuttiyon Mein Mauj Maza*.

All this he recounts with a small grin and a twinkle in his eye. Benegal has a history of making exactly the films he wants to make, and getting the funds to do so, sometimes from the private sector, sometimes from government bodies (notably, his 1976 film *Manthan* was financed by 500,000 dairy farmers contributing Rs 2 each, arguably the first ever crowd-funded movie). "[Funding] has always been the most difficult," he says. "Film is not inexpensive; somebody's got to cover the cost, either an audience or a sponsor."

Films made for the cinemas, for general audiences, must entertain, one way or another, he says. "That entertainment need not necessarily be this very commonly understood idea of entertainment, which means you go *dil behlane ke liye* [to humour yourself]. It may be to get people to think about something, about looking at life in a way that is not necessarily the way you are likely to see it normally, a view about people who are different from you."

"One of the reasons why I thought I would be a filmmaker is because film can deal with so many different kinds of subjects," says Benegal. "It's a form that can be exceedingly accessible compared to, say, a book. It has its limitations, of course, but the fact is that it still is a medium that is accessible to more people than people who are just literate."

Benegal's latest film, *Mujib*, a biopic on Bangladesh's founding father, was not one he had planned to make. "On the sidelines of a conference, Prime Minister [Narendra] Modi was speaking to [Bangladesh PM] Sheikh Hasina, and we have a kind of treaty between us about doing various things. The suggestion—I think from our prime minister—was why don't we make a film on Sheikh Mujib, and she said fine. And he asked, do you have any idea who we can ask from our side, and she named me, so that's how it turned out to be."



"IT TURNED OUT TO BE AN OUTSTANDING SUBJECT FOR US, BECAUSE IT WAS **THE STORY OF A MAN WHO GAVE BIRTH TO A NATION**," SAYS BENEGAL ABOUT HIS FILM **MUJIB**

"It turned out to be an outstanding subject for us, because it was the story of a man who gave birth to a nation," says Benegal. The director did not know a lot about his subject and had to read a great deal, and then meet his family, particularly his daughter, Prime Minister Hasina.

Benegal found the politically centrist Mujib appealing in other ways too: "He created what one might call, in many ways like us, a secular socialist republic. He didn't create an Islamic republic although the majority of people in